The Writing Process

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STEPS IN THE WRITING PROCESS

These are the five steps in the writing process:

1. Prewriting

2. Outlining the structure of ideas

3. Writing a rough draft

4. Revising

5. Editing

Effective writing

good ideas that are expressed well and arranged in the proper order

Although many more prewriting strategies exist, this presentation covers six:

using experience and observations,

freewriting,

asking questions,

brainstorming,

mapping,

and searching the Internet.

Prewriting

- the stage of the writing process during which you transfer your abstract thoughts into more concrete ideas in ink on paper (or in type on a computer screen).
- At this stage in the writing process, it is OK if you choose a general topic.

Prewriting: Choosing a Topic

- choosing a good general topic for an assignment is an essential step.
- Sometimes your instructor will give you an idea to begin an assignment
- Other times your instructor will ask you to come up with a topic on your own
- A good topic not only covers what an assignment will be about but also fits the assignment's **purpose** and its **audience**

Prewriting: Choosing a Topic

Using experience and observations

- When selecting a topic, you may also want to consider something that interests you or something based on your own life and personal experiences. Even everyday observations can lead to interesting topics.
- After writers think about their experiences and observations, they often take notes on paper to better develop their thoughts. These notes help writers discover what they have to say about their topic.

Prewriting: Choosing a Topic

Reading

- It first figures in the development of ideas and topics
- Different kinds of documents can help you choose a topic and also develop that topic.
    - For example, a magazine advertising the latest research on the threat of global warming may catch your eye in the supermarket. This cover may interest you, and you may consider global warming as a topic.
    - Or maybe a novel's courtroom drama sparks your curiosity of a particular lawsuit or legal controversy

Prewriting: Choosing a Topic

Reading

- critical reading is essential to the development of a topic.
- While reading almost any document, you evaluate the author's point of view by thinking about his main idea and his support

Prewriting: Choosing a Topic

Freewriting

- Freewriting is an exercise in which you write freely about any topic for a set amount of time (usually three to five minutes).
- During the time limit, you may jot down any thoughts that come to your mind.
- Try not to worry about grammar, spelling, or punctuation.
- Writing often comes easier when you have a personal connection with the topic you have chosen.

Prewriting: Choosing a Topic

Asking Questions

- Who? What? Where? When? Why? How?
- 5Ws
- 1H
  - Who will be my partner for the project?
  - When is the next meeting?
  - Why is my car making that odd noise? Even the title of
  - this chapter begins with the question “How do I begin?”

Figure 7.1 Asking Questions

Questions	Answers
Who?	I use media. Students, teachers, parents, employers and employees—almost everyone uses media.
What?	The media can be a lot of things. Television, radio, e-mail (I think), newspapers, magazines, books.
Where?	The media is almost everywhere now. It's in homes, at work, in cars, even on cell phones!
When?	Media has been around for a long time, but seems a lot more important now.
Why?	Hmm. This is a good question. I don't know why there is mass media. Maybe we have it because we have the technology now. Or people live far away from their families and they have to stay in touch.
How?	Well, media is possible because of the technology inventions, but I don't know how they all work!

Prewriting: Choosing a Topic

Brainstorming

- Similar to list making
- Start with a blank sheet of paper (or a blank computer document) and write your general topic across the top.
- Underneath your topic, make a list of more specific ideas
- Think of your general topic as a broad category and the list items as things that fit in that category
- Often you will find that one item can lead to the next, creating a flow of ideas that can help you narrow your focus to a more specific paper topic


Mass Media
Magazines
Newspapers
Broadcasting
Radio
Television
DVD
Gaming/video games
Internet
Cell phones
Smartphones
Text messages
Tiny cameras
GPS

Prewriting: Choosing a Topic

Idea Mapping

- allows you to visualize your ideas on paper using circles, lines, and arrows
- This technique is also known as clustering
  - ideas are broken down and clustered, or grouped together
- writers like this method because the shapes show how the ideas relate or connect, and writers can find a focused topic from the connections mapped

Prewriting: Choosing a Topic

Idea Mapping



Prewriting: Choosing a Topic

Searching the Internet

- Writers use search engines not only to understand more about the topic's specific issues but also to get better acquainted with their audience.
- Results from an Internet search show writers the following information:
  - Who is talking about the topic
  - How the topic is being discussed
  - What specific points are currently being discussed about the topic
- If the search engine results are not what you are looking for, revise your keywords and search again. Some search engines also offer suggestions for related searches that may give you better results.

Topic Checklist

The following checklist can help you decide if your narrowed topic is a good topic for your assignment.

- Am I interested in this topic?
- Would my audience be interested?
- Do I have prior knowledge or experience with this topic? If so, would I be comfortable exploring this topic and sharing my experiences?
- Do I want to learn more about this topic?
- Is this topic specific?
- Does it fit the length of the assignment?

Generating an Outline

Outlining is a tried and tested method learned in writing. Some people love it; others hate it.

Your computer software's outlining feature makes it easy for you to experiment with the organization and scope of information

Generating an Outline

I. Create Message

A. Preparing a Message
   1. Accessing the Create Message Menu
      a. Introduction
      b. Prerequisite
      c. Procedure
      d. Setting the Delivery Default
   2. Functions of the Create Message Screen
      a. Forwarding a Message
      b. Changing the Message Type
      c. Verifying the Address

B. Address Defaults
   1. Accessing the Address Defaults Screen
      a. Introduction
      b. Prerequisite
      c. Procedure
   2. Functions of the Address Defaults Screen
      a. Forwarding a Message
      b. Changing the Message Type
      c. Verifying the Address

II. Online Communication

A. Communicating with IMS
   1. (and so forth)

EXAMPLE 2-4: Traditional outline for a user manual.

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Methods of Organizing Writing

Table 7.1 Order versus Purpose

Order	Purpose
Chronological Order	To explain the history of an event or a topic
	To tell a story or relate an experience
	To explain how to do or make something
	To explain the steps in a process
Spatial Order	To help readers visualize something as you want them to see it
	To create a main impression using the senses (sight, touch, taste, smell, and sound)
Order of Importance	To persuade or convince
	To rank items by their importance, benefit, or significance

Editing vs. Revising

- Revising a piece of your own writing is more than just fixing errors—that's editing.
- happens before editing.
- involves re-seeing your essay from the eyes of a reader who can't read your mind, not resting satisfied until you're sure you have been as clear and as thorough as possible.
- also requires you to think on a large scale, to extrapolate: If a reader remarked that you didn't have enough evidence in paragraph three, you should also take a close look at paragraphs two and four to be sure that you provide substantial evidence for those claims as well.

Editing vs. Revising

An **edit** might be	A similar **Revision** might be	***Significant* Revision** might include
Adding a comma before a quote	Explaining one quotation better where a reader didn't understand	Explaining *several* quotations better, to improve the essay overall
Streamlining your thesis; cutting out unnecessary words	Adding *a "because…"* statement to your thesis sentence to express your "so, what?" up at the front	Changing *every* body paragraph so that each uses the same basic argument as the new thesis
Adding "In addition, . . ." to a paragraph to smooth a transition	Changing a paragraph's first-sentence *from summary to argument*, from "McCloud says…" to "What McCloud says about icons helps show Satrapi's _____ ."	Changing *all* first-sentences (and some last-sentences) so that they show your argument; adjusting the rest of each paragraph to reflect your argument
Shortening a long quote & working it into your sentence	*Choosing a better quotation* that gives a more specific or relevant idea; explaining exactly how that quote (which words?) uses pathos or supports your claim	Adding second-example quotes to *several* paragraphs; working quotes from Author A into paragraphs with quotes from Author B & drawing connections
Adding a sentence to fill out a paragraph	*Splitting a too-long paragraph* into two separate ones, each with a new starting & finishing sentence	Adding a whole paragraph or section with a new example, counterargument, or related theory to intensify/expand your analysis
Fixing apostrophe errors in your conclusion paragraph	Revising your *conclusion* by connecting ideas from 2-3 points or authors at once; tying your conclusion to your introductory images/ideas	Going "out on a limb" in the conclusion to get the "big picture" implications (for whom? why?) then adding some of that info back into ends of body paragraphs

Editing Checklist

- ✓ Does this paper fulfill all requirements of the **assignment?**
- ✓ Does this paper have a **thesis**? Is the thesis **specific**?
- ✓ Does this paragraph have **topic sentences** at the beginning of each body paragraph? Do the topic sentences both connect to the thesis and introduce what I will be talking about in the paragraph itself?
- ✓ Are there paragraphs that seem to be **too long** or **too short**? Are the paragraphs relatively similar lengths?
- ✓ Have I examined my paper for **excess repetition** (of words, phrases, sentence constructions)?
- ✓ Are there **transitions between paragraphs**?
- ✓ Are there **transitions between sentences**?
- ✓ Does the **conclusion** do more than simply repeat the introduction, or summarize my argument? Have I extrapolated anything meaningful? Have I explained to my audience why this paper is important to them?
- ✓ If quotations have been used, have they been smoothly **integrated** into the text with my own sentence both before and after the quote, including **signal phrases**?
- ✓ Have I properly formatted quotes over three lines (using block indentation)?
- ✓ Have I used an appropriate **number and variety of sources** (per the assignment requirements)?
- ✓ Have I documented paraphrases and quotations appropriately, using an **approved citation guide** (MLA, APA, etc.)?
- ✓ Does the paper have an **original, meaningful title**?
- ✓ Have I included **page numbers**?
- ✓ Have I maintained consistent use of **verb tense**?
- ✓ Have I used **strong verbs**?
- ✓ Have I used **active and passive voice appropriately**, given the field of writing?
- ✓ Have I read the entire paper **aloud**, one word at a time, to check for simple errors?
- ✓ Have I eliminated **unnecessary words**?
- ✓ Have I carefully proofread the paper for **spelling and punctuation**?